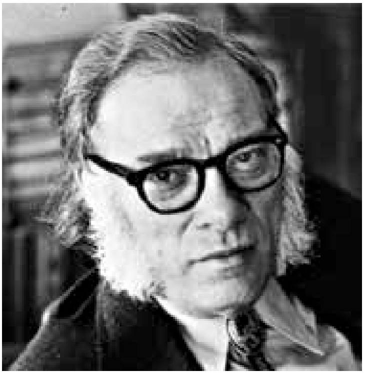
What could such rules be? And have any such rules already been framed? Read on to find out.

Asimov's three laws - are they truly enough?

American science fiction writer, Isaac Asimov, articulated the three laws of robotics, introducing them in a short story in 1942 called "Runaround." Till date, they are considered a benchmark in terms of basic laws, if nothing else, only because nothing better has been devised yet.

The three laws are as follows:

1. A robot may not injure a human being or, through inaction, allow a human being to come to harm
2. A robot must obey the orders given it by human beings except where such orders would conflict with the First Law
3. A robot must protect its own existence as long as such protection does not conflict with the First or Second Law



Will his laws protect us?

Even a casual reading of the laws will give you a feel of how simple and elegant they are. But while simplicity and elegance are great virtues in themselves, would the laws be functional in a real world scenario? That's the million dollar question.

Though a straightforward answer to the question may not be easy, the general perception is that implementing the laws are fraught with troubles.

For one thing, there are matters concerning the interpretation of the language which needs to be taken into account while defining the particular term "harm." For instance, while physically injuring or murdering someone is harming them, does scaring someone also qualify as the same? If yes, what if scaring a person could save them from more vicious harm?

An imaginary scenario involves a robot driver helming a bus with thirty passengers. The bus is going down a road at a high speed and as if from out of nowhere, a human comes onto the road. If the robot brakes hard or swerves the vehicle, it would harm the passengers. Otherwise, it would end up killing the person on the road. In this case, the robot would pit 30 lives against one and save the larger number.